

MUMBAI | Getting Their Way



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Sharad Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) may have fared poorly in the Maharashtra Assembly polls, but the party has proved itself a winner in political craftsmanship. First, the NCP leadership left no stone unturned in stalling the swearing in ceremony even a fortnight

NCP LEADERS R. R. PATIL, PRAFUL PATEL AND CHHAGAN BHUJBAL (L-R)

after the results were declared. Then they wrested control of plum portfolios that the Congress held dear. Despite Ashok Chavan's statement that the Home Department must remain with the chief minister, the NCP has arm twisted them into conceding that and other important portfolios—Energy, Rural Development and Finance—to their own leaders.

Says NCP Maharashtra spokesperson Prakash Binsale, "In the politics of alliance there is no one in a stronger or weaker position. As for the portfolios, NCP leaders only expressed their desire to handle departments that they believe they can run efficiently." *by Swati Mathur*

Cash Flow

An Indian Forest Service official recently spent more than 6,500 Euros (Rs 4.5 lakh) flying business class to Mexico City, Sao Paulo and the Peruvian capital of Lima to attend an international conference. Did someone say austerity?

KOLKATA | Seeking Its Due

The 192-year-old Presidency College may soon become a university. The idea, first mooted 32 years ago, has been on the backburner because Calcutta University and the CPI(M) bosses have been reluctant to grant autonomy to it. On November 10, the Presidency College's governing body agreed that the college should be upgraded to university status. It will then have total autonomy in academic, financial and administrative matters. This will also put an end to arbitrary transfers of teachers. However, the CPI(M) teachers' councils may try to abort the move. If



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that happens, Trinamool Congress leader Mamata Banerjee may use the move as an electoral issue in the next Assembly elections. *by Abhijit Dasgupta*

KERALA | Media Bite

The powerful Kerala Catholic Bishops' Conference (KCBC) has lashed out at the media, accusing it of being driven by "competitive commerce ... it glorifies violence, trivialises sexuality, increases divisions and encourages anti-social activities". The accusation was made in a pastoral letter issued by Bishop Mathew Anikkuzhikattil, chairman of KCBC's Family Commission. The letter has charged the media with wreaking havoc on individuals and society in general. The letter says that the media has reduced homes into a marketplace. "By nourishing greed and discontentment, the media has ravaged family life. Many run crazy after consumer goods without considering if they could afford them or not and end up in disasters."

The Bishop also slammed mobile phones, the Internet and social networks: "They encourage parochial and superfluous relationships. Social networks have led to sexual anarchy and even terrorism." The letter calls for keeping the media under a leash. "Instead of people controlling the media it is the other way around now," states the epistle.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan